‘Trinamoolisation’, the New Scourge

The BJP leadership in Bengal watches gloomily as local cadre behaviour begins to resemble that of the TMC, as allegations of extortion culture swell

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

state BJP chief, warned his errant flock, saying: “The party won’t be affected even if 20-25 MLAs are expelled.” A change in government “does not automatically transform the entire ecosystem”, he conceded gloomily. Two ministers, Dilip Ghosh and Agnimitra Paul, have warned cadres against the cut money culture. The takeover of taxi and auto unions, besides land-grabbing et al, even got the RSS magazine *Swastika* fuming against ‘Trinamoolisation’.

A video from Sandeshkhali, North 24 Parganas, recently went viral. The party’s mandal head was seen comparing BJP MLA Sanat Sardar with Sheikh Shahjahan, the area’s ex-TMC strongman who is now behind bars. Angry teachers and students, demonstrating for the transfer of a controversial school-in-charge, forced Sardar to exit hastily when he arrived to try and intervene.

Takeaways

- **BJP expels 30 cadre, suspends 250 for alleged extortion, corruption**
- **State chief, ministers, even RSS warn against ‘Trinamoolisation’**
- **Complaints pour in of land grab, extortion, cut money, unionisation**



INTERNAL FEUD BJP rival factions in a heated argument, Anandapur, Aug. 23

DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY

A SPREADING STAIN

In South 24 Parganas and Bardhaman, BJP MLAs are being accused of extracting money from residents using the threat of demolitions, as also from PWD contractors. On August 28, a North Kolkata worker was suspended for locking up the Entally police station for over an hour! A Kolkata mandal head was defrocked for demanding Rs 5 lakh from a realtor. A leader in Jamuria was arrested after allegedly seeking cut money from sand-laden trucks.

By self-diagnosis, it’s ‘Trinamoolisation’. Partly via ingestion. The Anandapur clash was said to be between old BJP workers and local strongmen come over from the TMC. “These people have only changed their flag, not their political culture,” says a partyman. But often, it’s osmosis—locally, the BJP has adjusted well to the culture it campaigned against. “We thought corruption, extortion et al had peaked with the TMC,” says an IAS officer. “But it’s surprising, the colours some MLAs are showing in just three months.” A district magistrate says, with the TMC, a minister or MLA made out-of-turn demands—now, he claims, even small-time workers feel emboldened to do so. ■